

## U.S. AND MEXICO TO BOOST TIES ON SECURITY

Pact, after Trump’s strike in Caribbean, reflects concerns over gunboat diplomacy.

By Patrick J. McDonnell and Cecilia Sánchez Vidal

MEXICO CITY — U.S. and Mexican officials agreed Wednesday to bolster co-operation on joint security concerns, including drug smuggling, illegal migration and arms trafficking, as Secretary of State Marco Rubio defended President Trump’s controversial decision to order an attack on an alleged smuggling boat in the Caribbean Sea.

The top U.S. diplomat held his first meeting with President Claudia Sheinbaum a day after the dramatic Pentagon strike raised the specter of a unilateral U.S. military attack on suspected cartel targets in Mexico.

Tuesday’s action on a vessel that had departed Venezuela killed 11 seaborne “narcoterrorists” who were transporting drugs destined for the United States, said Trump, who released what he described as a video of the attack.

In Mexico, Rubio hailed the strike, stating that traditional interdiction efforts had failed to stop the flow of drugs via the Caribbean. “What will stop them is when you blow them up,” Rubio told reporters in Mexico City. “You get rid of them.”

Such strikes may be ongoing and will probably continue, Rubio said, providing no additional details.

The secretary of State sidestepped a question about whether the action, which critics denounced as illegal under international law, signaled a return to “gunboat diplomacy” in a region where U.S. interventions have historically stoked resentment.

Although Trump said Tuesday’s attack took place in international waters, he has not ruled out strikes in Mexico, where his administration has designated half a dozen cartels as foreign terrorist organizations. He has pushed for the use of the military against drug smugglers. Trump has reportedly issued a secret order directing the Pentagon to strike at Latin American cartels.

According to the Trump administration, its ongoing deployment of warships in the southern Caribbean is [See Mexico, A4]



STEPHEN LAM San Francisco Chronicle / Getty Images

**FLAMES** from the 6-5 fire engulf a structure in the historic mining town of Chinese Camp, Calif., on Tuesday.

## Wildfires erupt in northern part of state, burning Gold Rush town

By Alex Wigglesworth and Summer Lin

Chinese Camp was once a bustling mining outpost for thousands of immigrants who worked the gold fields of the Southern Sierra. Then it was a historic landmark where tourists could revisit an often-forgotten chapter in California history.

On Tuesday, a wildfire raced through the remnants of the Tuolumne County town, raising worries about

what has been lost.

The destruction came as 22 wildfires erupted Tuesday in multiple locations in Calaveras, Stanislaus and Tuolumne counties during a burst of dry thunderstorms that produced more than 5,000 lightning strikes. The fires, which ranged from a few acres to several thousand acres, together had burned 13,371 acres as of Wednesday afternoon, according to the California Department of Forestry and Fire Protection.

The largest of the fires — the 6-5 fire — forced the evacuation of Chinese Camp, a California Gold Rush mining town where thousands of Chinese immigrants settled in the late 1800s. The fire was still uncontained as of Wednesday evening.

The extent of the damage in Chinese Camp wasn’t immediately clear pending an official review, said Emily Kilgore, public information officer with the Cal Fire Tuolumne Calaveras Unit.

About 61 people still live there.

Videos shared by local media outlets showed widespread devastation. Smoke billowed up from blackened pavement as flames licked at piles of rubble, power lines snaked across the street.

Chinese Camp began as a distribution center to move supplies out of nearby mining camps, namely from San Francisco to Stockton and then to the camp, according to the Tuolumne Historical [See Wildfires, A14]

## Schools navigate ‘opt-out’ ruling

Parents can refuse LGBTQ+ lessons for kids. How will that work?

By Thomas Peele and Howard Blume

As the new academic year begins, schools throughout California are grappling with how to carry out a recent U.S. Supreme Court ruling allowing parents to withdraw their child from classroom lessons on LGBTQ+ issues and other subjects that conflict with their “sincerely held religious beliefs.”

Attorneys and educators predict that implementing the high court ruling in *Mahmoud vs. Taylor* could prompt confusion and litigation as schools figure out the logistics of handling opt-out requests — including how religious belief claims can or should be verified and how to continue to teach students who are pulled out of classes during the school day.

“There is a lot of trepidation about how to handle this issue in a way that is legally compliant and [See Schools, A7]



CARLIN STIEHL Los Angeles Times

**STUDENTS** at Maya Angelou High School last month. Educators are figuring out how to handle requests to skip LGBTQ+ lessons.

## Artsy but problematic palms

This summer, the Los Angeles County Museum of Art, the city’s Bureau of Street Services and Metro planted 77 new Mexican fan palms on Wilshire Boulevard, mostly along the sidewalk and medians outside the museum’s new David Geffen Galleries.

Local environmentalists, who are lobbying hard for more shade trees in L.A., are decrying the decision. They say palm trees are expensive to maintain, highly flammable and hopeless at producing the shade Angelenos need to dull the heat that radiates off the city’s streets, sidewalks and other hardscape surfaces.

Metro planted at least 48 fan palms in the new medians it rebuilt near the museum as part of its D Line Subway Extension Project, between Fairfax and La Brea avenues, said Dave Sotero, Metro’s communications director.

Sotero said the palms, interspersed with about five pink-blooming silk floss [See LACMA, A14]

L.A. desperately needs shade. Yet flammable trees are taking up prime spots near LACMA.

By Jeanette Marantos



JULIANA YAMADA Los Angeles Times

**THE CITY** has planted 77 Mexican fan palms on Wilshire Boulevard, despite the trees’ lack of shade.

### Epstein accusers call on Congress

Survivors lobby lawmakers to release the files, decrying Trump’s dismissal of the issue as a hoax. **NATION, A6**

### L.A. project’s price tag grows

An expansion of the Convention Center will cost \$2.7 billion, alarming officials. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

### ‘Wizard of Oz’ in Vegas’ Sphere

Times film critic Amy Nicholson reviews the visually expanded but time-shortened movie. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

### Weather

Heat continues to ease. L.A. Basin: 89/66. **B6**

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## Area’s progress on homelessness at risk

L.A. County has 14% fewer living on streets than 2 years ago, but funding cuts loom.

By Andrew Khouri

There’s a long way to go, but the Los Angeles area appears to be making progress in its fight against homelessness.

In the city, data show homeless people are moving into new permanent supportive housing faster. Countywide, there were 14% fewer people living on the streets than two years earlier, according to the 2025 count.

Future progress could be much tougher, due in large part to a slowing economy that is reducing funding for homeless services and programs.

“Homelessness is an issue that responds well to

## States unite to counter CDC turmoil

Newly created West Coast alliance will offer its own public health guidance.

By Melody Gutierrez, Michael Wilner and Susanne Rust

SACRAMENTO — With the U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention in turmoil as vaccine skeptics gain influence in the Trump administration, California is partnering with Washington and Oregon to form a pact that will offer its own public health recommendations.

Govs. Gavin Newsom of California, Tina Kotek of Oregon and Bob Ferguson of Washington announced Wednesday the creation of the West Coast Health Alliance, which they said will provide science-based recommendations at a time when the nation’s top public health agency is reversing long-standing vaccine guidance.

Robert F. Kennedy Jr., the secretary of the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services and a loyal Trump ally, has dismissed top scientific advisors and fired top leadership at the CDC, moves that have shaken public confidence in its direction. And Kennedy has warned that more turnover could be coming.

President Trump’s mass firing of CDC doctors and scientists — and his blatant politicization of the agency — is a direct assault on the health and safety of the American people,” the three governors said in a joint statement Wednesday. “The CDC has become a political tool that increasingly peddles ideology instead of science, ideology that will lead to severe health consequences.”

The rebuke from the West Coast states reveals the escalating concerns about the life-and-death consequences of the Trump administration’s healthcare agenda. For decades, the CDC has been the nation’s trusted authority on vaccines — setting childhood immunization schedules, guiding which shots adults should receive and shaping state health policies across the country.

The states said the focus of their health alliance will be on providing evidence-based recommendations about who should receive immunizations while ensuring [See Health, A7]